

3.1.1 Buddhism

Students should be aware that Buddhism is one of the diverse religious traditions and beliefs in Great Britain today and that the main religious tradition in Great Britain is Christianity. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should study the beliefs, teachings and practices of Buddhism specified below and their basis in Buddhist sources of wisdom and authority. They should be able to refer to scripture and/or sacred texts where appropriate. Some texts are prescribed for study in the content set out below and questions may be set on them. Students may refer to any relevant text in their answers and AQA will publish a list of appropriate texts as part of the supporting material for this specification. These additional texts will not be required for study, alternatives may be used, and questions will not be set on them.

Students should study the influence of the beliefs, teachings and practices studied on individuals, communities and societies.

Common and divergent views within Buddhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout. Students may refer to a range of Buddhist perspectives in their answers, for example, Theravada, Mahayana, Zen and Pure Land. They must study the specific differences identified below.

3.1.1.1 Key Beliefs

The Dhamma (Dharma)

- The concept of Dhamma (Dharma).
- The concept of dependent arising (paticcasamupada).
- The Three Marks of Existence:
 - anicca (impermanence)
 - anatta (no fixed self)
 - dukkha (unsatisfactoriness of life, suffering).
- The human personality, in the Theravada and Mahayana traditions:
 - Theravada: the Five Aggregates (skandhas) of form, sensation, perception, mental formations, consciousness
 - Mahayana: sunyata, the possibility of attaining Buddhahood and Buddha-nature.
- Human destiny:
 - different ideals in Theravada and Mahayana traditions: Arhat (a 'perfected person') and Bodhisattva ideals
 - Buddhahood and the Pure Land.

The Buddha and the Four Noble Truths

- The Buddha's life and its significance:
 - the birth of the Buddha and his life of luxury
 - the Four Sights: illness, old age, death, holy man (Jataka 075)
 - the Buddha's ascetic life
 - the Buddha's Enlightenment.
- The Four Noble Truths:
 - suffering (dukkha) including different types of suffering
 - the causes of suffering (samudaya); the Three Poisons, ignorance, greed and hate
 - the end of craving (tanha), interpretations of nibbana (nirvana) and Enlightenment
 - the Eightfold Path (magga) to nibbana/nirvana; the pathas the Threefold Way: ethics (sila), meditation (samadhi) and wisdom (panna). Dhammapada 190–191.

3.1.1.2 Practices

Worship and festivals

- The nature, use and importance of Buddhist places of worship including temples, shrines, monasteries (viharas), halls for meditation or learning (gompas) and their key features including Buddha rupa, artefacts and offerings.
- Puja, the significance and role of puja/devotional ritual in the home and in the temple, including chanting, both as a devotional practice and as an aid to mental concentration, mantra recitation, use of malas.
- Meditation, the different aims, significance and methods of meditation:
 - Samatha (concentration and tranquillity) including mindfulness of breathing
 - Vipassana (insight) including zazen
 - the visualisation of Buddhas and Bodhisattvas.
- The practice and significance of different ceremonies and rituals associated with death and mourning in Theravada communities and in Japan and Tibet.
- Festivals and retreats and their importance to Buddhists in Great Britain today, including the celebrations, origins and significance of:

- Wesak
- Parinirvana Day.

Buddhist ethics

- Ethical teaching:
 - kamma (karma) and rebirth
 - compassion (karuna)
 - loving kindness (metta).
- The five moral precepts:
 - do not take life
 - do not take what is not given
 - do not misuse the senses
 - do not speak falsehoods
 - do not take intoxicants that cloud the mind.
- The six perfections in the Mahayanan tradition:
 - generosity
 - morality
 - patience
 - energy
 - meditation
 - wisdom, including how the individual develops these perfections within themselves.